

Master's Degree Program in **Data-Driven Marketing**

Specialization in
Digital Marketing & Analytics

The impact of Social Media Influencers, Influencer Transparency, and FOMO on tourist behavior

Generational Differences – Gen X, Millennials, and
Gen Z

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Generational Differences – Gen X, Millennials, and Gen Z

by

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Master Thesis presented as partial requirement for obtaining the Master's degree in Data-Driven Marketing, with a specialization in Digital Marketing & Analytics

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STATEMENT OF INTEGRITY

I hereby declare having conducted this academic work with integrity. I confirm that I have not used plagiarism, any form of undue use of information or falsification of results along the process leading to its elaboration. I further declare that I have fully acknowledged the Rules of Conduct and Code of Honor from the NOVA Information Management School.

Lisbon, 2025

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ABSTRACT

In the digital age, social media significantly shapes consumer behavior in the tourism. This study explores how exposure to social media influencers (SMIs), influencer transparency, and the fear of missing out (FOMO) affect tourist behavior across Generations X, Millennials, and Z. Data were collected from 552 respondents through an online questionnaire and analyzed using PLS-SEM and Multi-Group Analysis (MGA). The findings reveal generational differences, Generation X relies on influencer WOM and FOMO, driving impulsive purchases. Millennials are more cautious, with WOM and FOMO having weaker effects on impulsive behavior, and Generation Z is cost-conscious, with influencer exposure influencing travel intentions but not impulsive purchases. Influencer transparency had limited impact across younger cohorts. MGA results indicated significant differences between Generation X and the other generations, with Millennials and Gen Z lacking compositional invariance. The study contributes theoretically by revealing the emotional, social and peer-driven aspects of travel behavior across generations. Practically, it provides actionable insights for tourism marketers seeking to design more targeted and effective influencer campaigns in the tourism industry.

KEYWORDS

FOMO; Social Media Influencers; Influencer Transparency; Generations; Impulsive Purchasing Behavior; Travel Intentions

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS

AVE	Average Variance Extracted
FOMO	Fear of Missing Out
Gen X	Generation X
Gen Z	Generation Z
HTMT	Heterotrait-Monotrait Ratio
IPB	Impulsive Purchasing Behavior
IT	Influencer Transparency
NFI	Normed Fit Index
SMIs	Social Media Influencers
SRMR	Standardized Root Mean Square Residual
TI	Travel Intentions
WOM	Word-of-Mouth



1. INTRODUCTION

In today's digital era, social media has not only reshaped how individuals interact with the world but also serves as a crucial communication channel and an influential tool in decision-making. It significantly influences tourists' decision-making processes through dynamic content (Hernández-Ortega et al., 2024). With platforms like Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, and YouTube commanding billions of active users worldwide, social media has become a dominant force in consumer behavior, significantly impacting the tourism sector (Stephen, 2016). Within this sector, the rise of social media influencers (SMIs), who act as intermediaries between brands and consumers, plays an essential role as virtual travel advisors, guiding tourists' decision-making. These influencers provide engaging content, real-time recommendations, and reviews of captivating photos and videos, helping audiences evaluate destinations and accommodations and prioritize unique experiences (Pop et al., 2022). The growing leverage of SMIs in tourism marketing has triggered interest among tourism scholars in exploring this niche and its effectiveness in the field (Kapoor et al., 2022).

Unlike traditional advertisements, SMIs rely on personal narratives, trustworthiness, expertise, and credibility that shape followers' destination choices (Wahba et al., 2024). However, despite their growing influence, limited attention has been given to transparency as a defining characteristic of influencers and its impact on tourism purchasing decisions. This research gap underlines the need to understand how transparent content produced by SMIs influences consumer behavior in the tourism context.

However, the pervasive influence of social media also has downsides. One such phenomenon is the Fear of Missing Out (FOMO), a psychological response characterized by anxiety triggered by the perception that others are experiencing rewarding events that one is not part of (Przybylski et al., 2013). FOMO has been shown to influence tourist behavior, often prompting impulsive travel decisions as individuals attempt to replicate experiences they see online (Roberts & David, 2020; Ulucan, 2024). While FOMO's impact on tourism can be positive and negative, its effects vary across generations (Barry & Wong, 2020; Zorlu & Candan, 2023), with each group exhibiting distinct responses to FOMO-driven travel motivations.

Despite the growing body of research on SMIs, FOMO, and tourism behavior, most studies have focused narrowly on specific generational cohorts, limited tourism behaviors, or specific social media platforms (Chen et al., 2022; Choi et al., 2024; Leung et al., 2025; Ong et al., 2024). The interplay between FOMO, social media influencers, and tourism decision-making across multiple generational groups—Gen X, Millennials, and Gen Z—remains underexplored. This study aims to fill this gap by examining how influencer transparency affects tourism purchasing decisions and how FOMO influences travel intentions across different generations.



The research question guiding this study is: How do the impacts of exposure to social media influencers, influencer transparency, and FOMO on tourism behaviors differ across Gen X, Millennials, and Gen Z? This study explores the intersection of influencer transparency, exposure to SMIs, and FOMO in tourism decision-making, with a specific focus on generational differences.

To answering this question, the study is structured around the following objectives: (1) to examine the effect of exposure to SMIs on tourists' reliance on WOM; (2) to analyze the impact of influencer transparency on followers' travel intentions; (3) to investigate the influence of FOMO on impulsive tourism purchasing behavior; (4) to assess the direct effect of influencers on travel intentions; (5) to evaluate how exposure to SMIs contributes to FOMO among tourists; (6) to explore the relationship between travel intentions and impulsive purchases; and (7) to identify generational differences in responses to social media influence, transparency, and FOMO.

This research contributes to the growing field of tourism marketing by addressing critical gaps in understanding the role of social media influencers (SMIs), transparent content, and fear of missing out (FOMO) in influencing travel intentions among Gen X, Millennials, and Gen Z. The findings provide practical insights for tourism marketers on effectively utilizing FOMO to improve consumer engagement through personalized promotions, social media campaigns and influencer partnerships.

The dissertation begins with Chapter 1, which introduces the study's subject by outlining its background, problem, objectives, and relevance. Chapter 2 presents a literature review, establishes the theoretical foundation, formulates hypotheses, and develops the conceptual model. Chapters 3 and 4 outline the method, data collection, and analysis, followed by the results. Chapter 5 synthesizes and discusses the key findings, and Chapter 6 concludes the study, discusses theoretical and practical contributions, and offers recommendations for future studies.



2. LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 SOCIAL MEDIA INFLUENCERS AND TOURISM

2.1.1 THE ROLE OF SOCIAL MEDIA INFLUENCERS IN THE TOURISM SECTOR

The tourism industry is a critical driver of the global economy, contributing 9.1% to worldwide GDP in 2023, underscoring its position among the top five most prominent industries (Przybylski et al., 2013; World Travel and Tourism Council, 2023). Beyond its economic importance, tourism has become highly influential on social media (Chu et al., 2020), transforming how destinations are promoted and experienced, with SMLs as the main contributors to modern tourism marketing.

Social media influencers (SMLs) promote brands, products, services, or destinations through sponsored content and direct interactions, increasing brand reach, sales, and follower interaction (Kim et al., 2021). By sharing authentic experiences and opinions, they foster emotional connections and influence followers' and prospective followers' decisions and purchasing behaviors (Kapoor et al., 2022). Their niche expertise and personal engagement strengthen brand relationships and encourage meaningful conversations (Ge & Gretzel, 2018).

The rise of social media has reshaped how tourists seek and use information (Xiang et al., 2015), making influencers essential in the industry. Beyond creating promotional content, they offer valuable travel information, inspiring and influencing tourist decisions (Han & Chen, 2022). They frequently endorse destinations or hotels through visual content, photos, and videos, across multiple social media platforms (Chen et al., 2022).

Contemporary tourists increasingly utilize social media to access shared travel experiences, explore, and evaluate tours, services, and destinations (Wahba et al., 2024). Social media is an emerging channel in tourism that elicits cognitive responses and promotes customers' affective responses (Polat et al., 2024). Platforms like Instagram have been widely adopted by SMLs as marketing tools due to their diverse features, allowing users to create and share content easily (Jin & Ryu, 2020). Meanwhile, TikTok is emerging as an increasingly influential platform, offering short-form visual content that showcases destinations and influences travel trends. According to Booking.com's 2023 travel trends survey, 30% of global travelers use TikTok for travel inspiration and 54% use it to discover destination ideas (Booking, 2023).

Tourism marketing now combines traditional approaches with influencer campaigns (Polat et al., 2024; Wahba et al., 2024). Travel influencers act as tourism destination marketers, boosting regional reputation and influencing travel decisions (Guerreiro et al., 2019), while educating audiences about destinations, culture, transport, activities, accommodations, attractions, food, and the environment (Stoldt et al., 2019).



2.1.2 RELIANCE ON WORD-OF-MOUTH (WOM) FROM INFLUENCERS

Word-of-mouth (WOM) opinion leaders effectively communicate their product experiences to other consumers (Langaro et al., 2019; Santos et al., 2023). Their influence extends beyond personal networks, generating engagement through likes, comments, and shares. Their reviews serve as trusted sources of information, reducing uncertainty in travel decisions by offering recommendations and firsthand insights.

In the tourism sector, influencers' WOM impacts purchasing intentions, increasing the likelihood of actual purchases and information-sharing behavior (Wang & Yu, 2017). Therefore, SMIs create a spillover effect on the decision-making journey.

H1: Exposure to social media influencers positively influences tourists' reliance on WOM from influencers.

WOM is a highly influential source of information in consumer decision-making processes (Chevalier & Mayzlin, 2006). This type of communication is, therefore, essential for tourists to create an image of the destination or hotel before acquiring the product (Beerli & Martín, 2004). In the digital age, social media further amplifies this effect, positively influencing consumer purchasing intentions (Pjero & Kërcini, 2015).

Beyond reducing uncertainty, WOM can also trigger impulsive purchasing behavior, a significant part of travelers' spending (Hanks & Mattila, 2014). Situational stimulus, such as exposure to web-based navigation tools during trips (Kah & Lee, 2014) or on-site promotional factors (Chang et al., 2014) can stimulate unplanned travel product consumption. Given the influential role of SMIs, exposure to them likely strengthens reliance on WOM and increases impulsive purchase tendencies.

H2: Reliance on influencers' word-of-mouth (WOM) has a positive effect on impulsive purchasing behavior among travelers.

2.1.3 THE ROLE OF TRANSPARENT CONTENT AND TRANSPARENT INFLUENCERS

Social media influencers have become influential figures in marketing, frequently sharing personal experiences and opinions about brands. However, audiences increasingly express skepticism, finding it difficult to distinguish genuine endorsements from financially motivated content (Kapoor et al., 2022). This uncertainty can undermine followers' trust and affect their travel-related decisions.

To address this, the Federal Trade Commission requires influencers to disclose sponsorships, helping audiences recognize the persuasive intent behind branded content (Carlson, 2015; Federal Trade Commission, 2017; Wojdynski & Evans, 2016). Transparency through disclosure is therefore a key mechanism for sustaining authenticity and credibility. Nevertheless, studies indicate that audiences often



overlook disclosures when viewing sponsored content (Carlson, 2015; Wojdyski & Evans, 2016). The effectiveness of disclosure depends on position (Wojdyski et al., 2018), format (Boerman & Müller, 2022), wording (e.g., #ad, #sponsored, #sponsoredpost) (De Jans et al., 2020), and level of detail (Boerman et al., 2015).

Repeated exposure to influencer content, particularly when accompanied by clear disclosures, enhances followers' sense of transparency. This perceived transparency strengthens product evaluations and purchase intentions (Reynolds & Yuthas, 2008) which, in the tourism context, translates into stronger travel intentions.

H3: Influencer transparency positively influences followers' travel intentions.

Despite these challenges, transparency has potential benefits for all stakeholders. For followers, it provides crucial information for more conscious decisions, especially regarding travel purchases. For influencers, openness reinforces honesty and authenticity, thereby enhancing credibility. For sponsoring brands, transparent practices improve consumer-brand relationships and behavioral outcomes (Dhanesh & Duthler, 2019).

However, transparency is not always perceived uniformly. Some marketers fear that disclosure may harm audience perceptions (De Veirman & Hudders, 2020), while other studies suggest that disclosure can generate positive attitudes toward the ad and its endorsers (C. Campbell & Marks, 2015). Maintaining trust and transparency is crucial, as consumers tend to place greater trust in influencers they perceive as authentic (Przybylski et al., 2013).

H4: Exposure to social media influencers positively influences the perceived transparency of influencers.

2.2 FEAR OF MISSING OUT (FOMO) AND TOURISM

2.2.1 PSYCHOLOGICAL FOUNDATIONS OF FOMO ON SOCIAL MEDIA

FOMO (Fear of Missing Out) is the anxiety arising from the belief that others may be having rewarding experiences that they do not have (Przybylski et al., 2013). It generates a constant desire to stay connected (Mohanani & Kushe Shekhar, 2021). Its prominence has grown on social media since the 2010s, amplifying its impact on individuals both personally and as consumers (Holte, 2023), influencing mental health, social behavior, and consumer habits (Roberts & David, 2020). Its consumption dimension has recently drawn attention, as individuals exhibit intense purchasing behavior to escape this fear, which they have, in a sense, surrendered (Przybylski et al., 2013).

One key FOMO perspective relates to social comparison, in which individuals compare their lives with others' idealized portrayals, leading to jealousy and dissatisfaction



(Chotpitayasunondh & Douglas, 2016). The constant exposure to online information also creates uncertainty and compulsion to stay updated (Przybylski et al., 2013). FOMO aligns with the human need for connection and belonging, motivating participation in social events or conversations to avoid exclusion (Elhai et al., 2018). Moreover, social media motivation and addiction further intensify FOMO (Kuss & Griffiths, 2017).

Although social media enhances connectivity, it also intensifies negative emotions such as FOMO, contributing to higher levels of anxiety and stress (Andreassen et al., 2017), reduced self-esteem and well-being, increased dissatisfaction, and stronger tendencies toward impulsive behavior and immediate gratification (Hamizar et al., 2024).

H5: Exposure to social media influencers influences tourists' FOMO.

2.2.2 IMPACT OF FOMO ON IMPULSIVE PURCHASING BEHAVIOR IN TOURISM

In tourism, the fear of missing out (FOMO) manifests as a fear of missing opportunities, such as leisure vacations, social interactions, and exclusive offers. Travelers are more concerned with the experiences that the destination can offer them (Ryu et al., 2021). Previous research shows that advertisements containing FOMO messages for hedonic products can increase purchase likelihood, because consumers are more willing to pay for what they perceive as unmissable (Dinh & Lee, 2022).

FOMO is an emotional response that affects every stage of the purchase process, often leading to impulsive behavior, in which travelers book trips spontaneously without detailed planning (Song et al., 2023). Social media intensifies this tendency by creating urgency through the constant exposure to travel-related content (Liu et al., 2019). Visually appealing posts, stories, and videos generate emotional responses that encourage spontaneous bookings, often overlooking practical factors, such as time, location, and budget (Vayghan et al., 2023).

H6: FOMO increases impulsive purchasing behavior in tourism.

2.3 TRAVEL INTENTIONS AND SOCIAL MEDIA INFLUENCERS

As defined by Cheng et al. (2020), travel intention is a form of behavioral intention that reflects an individual's dedication to travel. This results in a mental process of evaluating the pros and cons of all available options and converting motivation into action. Similarly, Lam and Luo (2020) describe travel intention more succinctly as an individual's desire to travel.

With the widespread popularity of social media, sharing travel experiences has become a normalized practice, including travel photography, videos, and other content



(Lo & McKercher, 2015). This constant exposure fosters spontaneous travel, as individuals now intentionally prefer unplanned travels and brief plans (Kah & Lee, 2014).

Social media influencers significantly shape these behaviors. Their trustworthiness and content quality strongly influence followers' travel intentions (McNair, 2021). Based on stimulus and cognitive appraisal theories, influencer-generated content can inspire individuals to travel. Based on this, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H7: Exposure to social media influencers has a positive impact on travel intentions.

Most studies emphasize the conscious aspects of travel behavior influenced by social media, often overlooking the unconscious dimensions, such as impulsive travel intentions (Guan et al., 2024). However, the prevalence of social platforms has made impulsive travel decisions increasingly common (Yao et al., 2021). Despite this, limited research explores how social media shapes these spontaneous behaviors (Um et al., 2023).

H8: Travel intentions positively impact impulsive purchasing behavior.

2.4 GENERATIONAL DIFFERENCES IN TOURISM

The age of travelers plays a vital role in shaping travel preferences and tourism experiences. Recreational demand can be effectively predicted based on age, as tourist profiles vary according to socioeconomic status, travel experience, and motivations (Yoga, 2018). Older travelers tend to exhibit more conservative habits, while younger tourists prefer adventurous and experience-driven behaviors. Interestingly, older travelers tend to have more positive attitudes toward tourism activities (Sinclair-Maragh, 2017).

A generation is defined as a group of people born in the same period, shaped by the cultural circumstances experienced (W. K. Campbell et al., 2015; McCrindle, 2009). Different generations of tourists have different attitudes and consumption habits. Generations play a moderating role in the relationship between social media communication and behavioral intention (Llopis-Amorós et al., 2019). Tourists can be grouped into Baby Boomers, Generation X, Millennials, Generation Z, and Generation Alpha.

2.4.1 GEN X TRAVELERS

Gen X, born between 1965 and 1976 (Norum, 2003), comprises approximately 49 million individuals. They balance traditional values and technological adaptability, often relying on WOM and personal recommendations when planning travel (Adnan & Omar, 2022), while also embracing technological innovations that enhance their travel experience.



Social media influences Gen X differently from younger cohorts. Gen X travelers are shaped by experiences of age-related stereotypes (Bae & Jo, 2024; Grigsby & Skiba, 2022) and adopt a younger age identity, a phenomenon known as “youth bias” (Montepare, 2009), which can influence consumer behavior and encourage disassociation from older age groups (Amatulli et al., 2018). They tend to trust recommendations from influencers closer to their own age (Leung et al., 2025). Overall, Gen X travelers value comfort, safety, and efficiency, but remain open to technology that simplifies their travel experience. Although influential, their tourism market has declined as Millennials and Generation Z gain dominance in spending power and population (Childers & Boatwright, 2021).

2.4.2 MILLENNIAL TRAVELERS

Millennials, also known as Generation Y, were born between 1977 and 1994 (Broadbridge et al., 2007), and are the first digitally native generation. Technology and social media are central to their daily lives and social interactions (Krishnan, 1996). For them, travel is a necessity rather than a luxury, driven by intrinsic motivations such as exploring new places, seeking adventure, and self-fulfillment (Kabir & Hassan, 2024; Rita et al., 2019).

They use social media to document and share their travel experiences and inspire others (Amaro et al., 2019). They often seek budget-friendly travel options, such as backpacking or working abroad, to fund trips (Demolingo et al., 2021). The sharing economy, including ride-sharing and peer-to-peer accommodations platforms, aligns with their values of flexibility and affordability (Saseanu et al., 2020). As a result, Millennials have emerged as a significant demographic in the global tourism industry, influencing current trends and future directions (Kumar et al., 2024).

2.4.3 GEN Z TRAVELERS

Generation Z, born between 1995 and 2010, also known as the Centennials (Llopis-Amorós et al., 2019; Priporas et al., 2020) is the first cohort fully immersed in digital technology. They are tech-savvy, innovative, and creative (Priporas et al., 2017) and more diverse and unique than any previous generation (Shatto & Erwin, 2016).

Unlike Millennials, Gen Z travelers are cost-conscious, deliberate, and prioritize quality and value, thoroughly researching purchases and seeking deals (Liu et al., 2023). Their travel decisions are strongly shaped by online content and digital interactions. For them, travel extends beyond sightseeing; it fosters social connection, personal growth, and meaningful experiences, including engagement with locals and new



friendships (Haddouche & Salomone, 2018). The internet and digital technologies significantly influence their travel behavior and preferences.

2.5 CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

This section presents the conceptual model developed to guide the study and achieve its objectives.

The study examines the causal relationships between social media influencers' exposure, FOMO, influencer transparency, and their effects on impulsive purchasing behavior, reliance on influencers' WOM, and travel intentions (Figure 1).

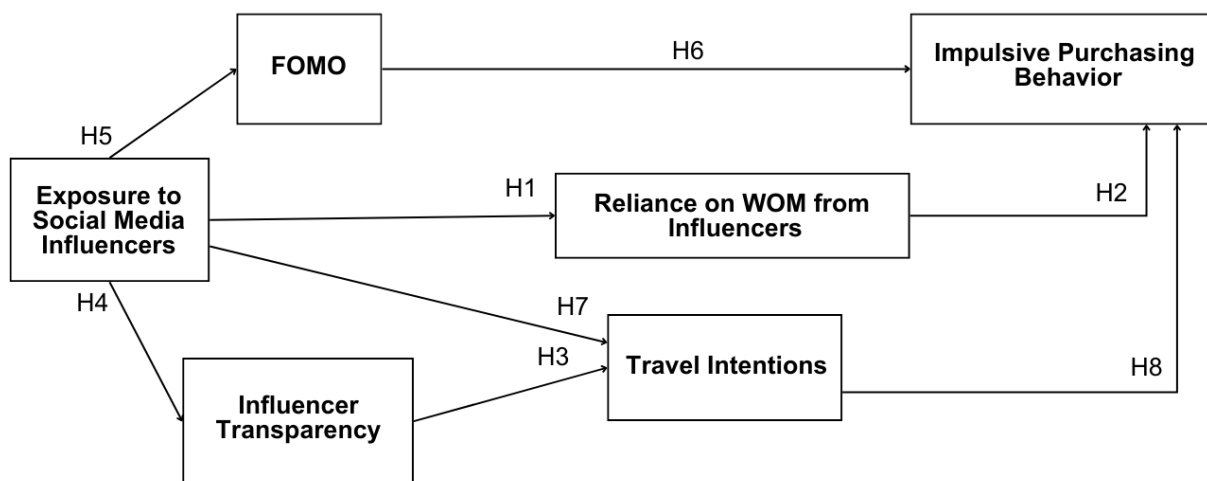


Figure 1 – Conceptual Model



3. METHODOLOGY

3.1 RESEARCH PROCEDURE

The study employed a quantitative research approach through survey research. Data were collected through an online questionnaire available in English, distributed via Qualtrics and shared on Instagram, LinkedIn, WhatsApp, and email. Confidentiality was maintained, and data were used exclusively for academic purposes in compliance with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR).

A pre-test of the questionnaire was conducted to assess its validity, reliability, and item clarity, enabling adjustments to enhance the instrument's effectiveness.

The target population comprised Generation X (1965-1976), Millennials (1977-1994), and Generation Z (1995-2010) consumers who travel regularly, actively use social media, and follow travel influencers. Participants were selected through convenience sampling, ensuring that only respondents meeting these criteria were included. The final sample size was determined by the number of valid responses obtained during the data collection period, resulting in 552 responses.

3.2 QUESTIONNAIRE DESIGN

The questionnaire comprised eight sections covering: participant qualifications; FOMO; exposure to social media influencers; influencer transparency; impulsive purchasing behavior; reliance on influencers' WOM; travel intentions; and demographics.

It began with an introduction explaining the study's purpose, estimated completion time, and informed consent, followed by a qualifying question to exclude participants who did not follow travel influencers. Qualified respondents then answered questions about their social media habits, platform preferences, and the frequency with which they purchase products promoted by influencers. Subsequent sections measured FOMO among individuals who follow travel influencers, using items adapted from the FOMO Scale (Przybylski et al., 2013). The third section assessed exposure to social media influencers using items adapted from Dinh et al. (2022), while the fourth section evaluated influencer transparency using items from Woodroof et al. (2020). The fifth section examined impulsive purchasing behaviors using a scale developed by Badgaiyan & Verma (2015), and the sixth section focused on reliance on influencers' WOM, using items adapted from Vinoi et al. (2025). The seventh section examined participants' travel intentions and the impact of social media on destination choices, drawing on the scale developed by Frash & Blose (2019). An attention check was embedded before the final section to identify inattentive respondents. The final section collected demographic data, including age, gender, nationality, education level, current professional status, and monthly income.



Most questionnaire items were measured on a seven-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree), to capture respondents' agreement, as this format provides precision and efficiency in online surveys (Finstad, 2010). Exposure to social media influencers was measured using a seven-point frequency scale (1 = never to 7 = very often). All constructs and items are presented in Table 1.

Table 1 - Constructs and measures

Construct	Original item	Adapted item	Reference
FOMO	I fear others have more rewarding experiences than I. I fear my friends have more rewarding experiences than I. I get worried when I find out my friends are having fun without me. I get anxious when I don't know what my friends are up to. It is important that I understand my friends' "in jokes". Sometimes, I wonder if I spend too much time keeping up with what is going on. It bothers me when I miss an opportunity to meet up with friends. When I have a good time, it is important for me to share the details online (e.g., updating status). When I miss out on a planned get-together, it bothers me. When I go on vacation, I continue to keep tabs on what my friends are doing.	F1: I fear others have more rewarding experiences than I. F2: I fear that my friends have more rewarding experiences than I do. F3: I feel worried when I find out my friends are having fun without me. F4: I feel anxious when I don't know what my friends are up to. F5: I feel it is important to understand my friends' inside jokes. F6: I sometimes wonder if I spend too much time trying to keep up with what others are doing. F7: I feel bothered when I miss an opportunity to meet up with friends. F8: When I have a good time, I feel it is important to share details online (e.g., updating status). F9: I feel bothered when I miss a planned get-together with friends. F10: When I go on vacation, I continue to keep tabs on what my friends are doing.	Przybylski et al., 2013, p. 1847
Exposure to Social Media Influencers	How frequently do you watch content generated by this influencer on social media? How frequently do you watch selfies posted by this influencer on social media? How frequently do you watch live streaming of this influencer on social media?	SMI1: How frequently do you watch post/video content generated by social media influencers on social media? SMI2: How frequently do you watch selfies posted by social media influencers on social media? SMI3: How frequently do you watch live streaming of social media influencers on social media?	Pan et al., 2022, p. 4
Influencer Transparency	[INFLUENCER] is honest about the post [he/she] was paid to make. I can rely on [INFLUENCER] to post only products [he/she] believes in. I can rely on [INFLUENCER] to post only products [he/she] personally uses.	IT1: The influencers I follow are honest about the posts they are paid to make. IT2: I can rely on the influencers I follow to post only products they believe in IT3: I can rely on the influencers I follow to post only products they personally use.	Woodroof et al., 2020, p. 679
Impulsive Purchasing Behavior	I ended up spending more money than I originally set out to spend.	IPB1: I ended up spending more money on travel than I originally planned.	Badgaiyan & Verma, 2015, p. 152



	I bought more than what I had planned to buy. I indulged in impulsive buying,	IPB2: I booked more trips and travel experiences than I had planned. IPB3: I indulged in impulsive travel decisions.	
Reliance on WOM from Influencers	I would like to continue following recommendations from hospitality virtual influencers. I would like to continue implementing suggestions from hospitality virtual influencers. I intend to keep following the hospitality virtual influencer's recommendations rather than seeking advice elsewhere. It is likely that I will continue to rely on the hospitality virtual influencer's recommendations in the future.	WOM1: I would like to continue following travel recommendations shared by social media influencers. WOM2: I would like to continue implementing travel suggestions I hear from social media influencers. WOM3: I intend to keep following travel recommendations from social media influencers rather than seeking advice from other sources. WOM4: I will likely continue to rely on travel recommendations from social media influencers in the future.	Vinoi et al. 2025, p. 339
Travel Intentions	It is my intention to take a motorcycle trip again soon. Before long, I really want to travel on my motorcycle. I will try to travel on my motorcycle in the near future.	TI1: I intend to take another leisure trip soon. TI2: Before long, I really want to travel to a new destination. TI3: I will try to go on a trip in the near future.	Frash & Blose, 2019, p. 524

3.3 DATA ANALYSIS

The collected data were analyzed using Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) with SmartPLS 4.0. This technique was chosen for its effectiveness in examining complex relationships among latent constructs and for its suitability for exploratory research involving predictive models (Hair et al., 2020).

3.4 SAMPLE DESCRIPTION AND DEMOGRAPHIC PROFILE

After data cleaning, incomplete responses, and ineligible participants, 552 valid responses were retained for analysis. Participants had to belong to Generation X, Millennials, or Generation Z; had previous travel experience; and follow at least one travel influencer. Data were collected from May 7 to July 11, 2025.

The sample comprised 40.8% males and 59.2% females, aged 15 to 60 years, with Generation Z representing the largest group (36.8%; Tables 2 and 3). Most held a Bachelor's Degree (62.1%) and were employed full-time (66.7%), while 19.6% were students. The majority were Portuguese (93.7%), with smaller representations from Angola, Brazil, Italy, Spain, Russia, the US, and Ukraine.

Table 2 - Sample demographic

Measurement	Value	Number	%
Gender	Female	327	59.2%



	Male	225	40.8%
Generations	Generation Z (15-30 years old)	203	36.8%
	Millennials (31-48 years old)	180	32.6%
	Generation X (49-60 years old)	169	30.6%
Education Level	PhD	7	1.3%
	Master's Degree	127	23%
	Bachelor Degree	343	62.1%
	High School	75	13.6%
Current Professional Situation	Full-time employed	368	66.7%
	Part-time employed	13	2.3%
	Self-employed	32	5.8%
	Student	108	19.6%
	Retired	11	2%
	Unemployed	10	1.8%
	Other	10	1.8%
Monthly Net Income	Less than €1.000	95	17.2%
	€1.000-€1.999	126	22.8%
	€2.000-€2.999	155	28.1%
	€3.000-€3.999	96	17.4%
	€4.000-€4.999	11	2%
	More than €5.000	8	1.4%
	Prefer not to answer	61	11.1%



4. RESULTS

Distinct generational patterns were found in travel frequency and social media usage (Table 3). Generation X respondents reported traveling once a year most often (52.1%), whereas both Millennials and Generation Z reported traveling several times a year (67.8% and 49.3%, respectively).

Social media use was widespread among all generations, with daily access reported by 80.5% Gen X participants, 86.1% of Millennials, and 95.6% of Gen Z participants. However, the duration of daily usage varied: Gen X primarily used social media for 30 minutes to 1 hour (65.1%), Millennials for 1 to 2 hours (63.3%), and Gen Z for 2 to 4 hours (45.3%), highlighting increasing engagement among younger generations.

Platform preference also differed. Facebook remained the dominant platform for Gen X, preferred by 62.1% of participants. Interestingly, no Gen Z respondents selected Facebook as their most frequently used platform. Instead, Instagram was the preferred platform for both Millennials (55%) and Gen Z (63.1%).

Regarding the influence of social media on purchasing decisions, a majority of Gen X participants (63.3%) reported that influencers rarely affect their decisions. In contrast, Millennials (67.2%) and Gen Z (42.4%) stated that influencers occasionally impact their decisions, suggesting a growing influence of digital personalities on consumer behavior among younger users.



Table 3 - Social Media and Travel Behavior

	Value	Generation X	Millennials	Generation Z
Frequency of Traveling	Several times a year	43 (25.4%)	122 (67.8%)	100 (49.3%)
	Once a year	88 (52.1%)	43 (23.9%)	72 (35.4%)
	Rarely	38 (22.5%)	15 (8.3%)	31 (15.3%)
Frequency of access to social media platforms	Daily	136 (80.5%)	155 (86.1%)	194 (95.6%)
	A few times per week	16 (9.4%)	15 (8.3%)	4 (2%)
	A few times per month	14 (8.3%)	7 (3.9%)	2 (1%)
	Rarely	3 (1.8%)	3 (1.7%)	3 (1.4%)
Time per day spent on social media	Less than 30 minutes	20 (11.8%)	12 (6.7%)	2 (1%)
	30 minutes - 1 hour	110 (65.1%)	29 (16.1%)	23 (11.3%)
	1 - 2 hours	27 (15.9%)	114 (63.3%)	51 (25.1%)
	2 - 4 hours	11 (6.5%)	17 (9.4%)	92 (45.3%)
	More than 4 hours	1 (0.6%)	8 (4.4%)	35 (17.2%)
Most used social media platform	Instagram	49 (29%)	99 (55%)	128 (63.1%)
	Facebook	105 (62.1%)	28 (15.6%)	0
	TikTok	6 (3.6%)	36 (20%)	60 (29.6%)
	YouTube	8 (4.7%)	11 (6.1%)	11 (5.4%)
	X (Twitter)	0	3 (1.7%)	3 (1.4%)
	Other	1 (0.6%)	3 (1.7%)	1 (0.5%)
How often do influencers impact purchase decisions	Very often	0	0	6 (3%)
	Frequently	7 (4.1%)	15 (8.3%)	38 (18.7%)
	Occasionally	51 (30.2%)	121 (67.2%)	86 (42.4%)
	Rarely	107 (63.3%)	35 (19.4%)	62 (30.5%)
	Never	4 (2.4%)	9 (5%)	11 (5.4%)

4.1 MEASUREMENT MODEL ASSESSMENT

A Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) approach was employed in SmartPLS to assess the measurement and structural models. A Multigroup Analysis (MGA) was subsequently conducted to compare the effects of social media influencers, FOMO, and influencer transparency across different generational groups, with generation as a moderating variable.

Reliability and validity analysis were examined to evaluate the measurement model. Table 4 reports the mean, standard deviation, outer loadings, and p-values for all generations. Following standard guidelines for reflective models, only items with loadings of 0.7 or greater were retained. Outer loading significance was assessed through bootstrapping with 5,000 subsamples. Twelve items (SMI3, WOM4, F1, F2, F3, F5, F6, F7, F9, F10, TI1, and TI3) presented low loadings and were removed due to poor correlations with their constructs.

Table 4 - Measurement and statistics – All generations



Construct	Indicators	Mean	Std deviation	P value	Loadings
Exposure to SMI	SMI1	0.812	0.029	0.000	0.817
	SMI2	0.826	0.026	0.000	0.828
Influencer Transparency	IT1	0.825	0.026	0.000	0.827
	IT2	0.916	0.010	0.000	0.917
	IT3	0.814	0.031	0.000	0.815
Reliance on WOM from Influencers	WOM1	0.733	0.041	0.000	0.737
	WOM2	0.788	0.030	0.000	0.791
	WOM3	0.813	0.027	0.000	0.813
FOMO	F4	0.497	0.435	0.112	0.692
	F8	0.465	0.489	0.143	0.716
Travel Intentions	TI2	0.986	0.018	0.000	0.996
Impulsive Purchasing Behavior	IPB1	0.855	0.015	0.000	0.854
	IPB2	0.876	0.012	0.000	0.876
	IPB3	0.864	0.014	0.000	0.867

After re-estimating the model, all remaining items demonstrated adequate reliability and convergent validity.

Table 5 shows that all multi-item constructs (SMI, IT, WOM, FOMO, and IPB) present satisfactory internal consistency, with Cronbach's Alpha and Composite Reliability values above 0.70 threshold. For Travel Intentions, the reliability values equal 1.000 because it is a single-item construct, and internal consistency cannot be assessed in this case (Hair et al., 2020).

Convergent validity was also supported, as all constructs exhibited acceptable Average Variance Extracted (AVE) values, confirming that they adequately explain the variance of their indicators.

Table 5 - Construct Reliability and Validity – All generations

	Cronbach's Alpha	Composite reliability (rho_a)	Composite reliability (rho_c)	Average variance extracted (AVE)
SMI	0.668	0.677	0.857	0.750
IT	0.813	0.836	0.888	0.726
WOM	0.718	0.780	0.828	0.616
FOMO	0.729	0.809	0.877	0.781
TI	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
IPB	0.832	0.833	0.899	0.749

All constructs meet the Fornell-Larcker criterion for discriminant validity, with each construct's AVE square root exceeding its correlations with other constructs (Table 6).



Table 6 - Fornell-Larcker criterion – All generations

	FOMO	IPB	IT	SMI	TI	WOM
FOMO	0.884					
IPB	0.253	0.865				
IT	-0.058	0.150	0.852			
SMI	0.080	0.318	0.311	0.866		
TI	0.365	0.414	-0.127	0.212	1.000	
WOM	0.124	0.431	0.484	0.481	0.253	0.785

Table 7 demonstrates strong discriminant validity for all constructs, as all HTMT values remain below the recommended threshold of 0.9 (Teo et al., 2008). This confirms that the constructs are distinct and supports the discriminant validity already indicated by the Fornell-Larcker criterion.

Table 7 - HTMT – All generations

	FOMO	IPB	IT	SMI	TI
IPB	0.323				
IT	0.231	0.206			
SMI	0.134	0.427	0.423		
TI	0.439	0.452	0.229	0.260	
WOM	0.201	0.464	0.641	0.667	0.293

To complete this analysis, the HTMT confidence interval was also analyzed using bootstrap resampling, and the upper limit is below 1 for all intervals, consistent with the demonstrated discriminant validity (Teo et al., 2008) (Table 8).

Table 8 - HTMT Confidence intervals – All generations

	2.5%	97.5%
IPB <-> FOMO	0.218	0.435
IT <-> FOMO	0.189	0.298
IT <-> IPB	0.145	0.300
SMI <-> FOMO	0.070	0.232
SMI <-> IPB	0.324	0.534
SMI <-> IT	0.313	0.530
TI <-> FOMO	0.356	0.523
TI <-> IPB	0.375	0.523
TI <-> IT	0.173	0.287
TI <-> SMI	0.170	0.347
WOM <-> FOMO	0.143	0.293
WOM <-> IPB	0.384	0.543
WOM <-> IT	0.526	0.746
WOM <-> SMI	0.548	0.776
WOM <-> TI	0.193	0.382



4.2 STRUCTURAL MODEL ASSESSMENT

After confirming the validity and reliability of the measurement model, the structural model was evaluated to test the hypothesized relationships between constructs across all generations (Figure 2). Only H5 was not statistically significant ($p > 0.05$, $t < 1.96$).

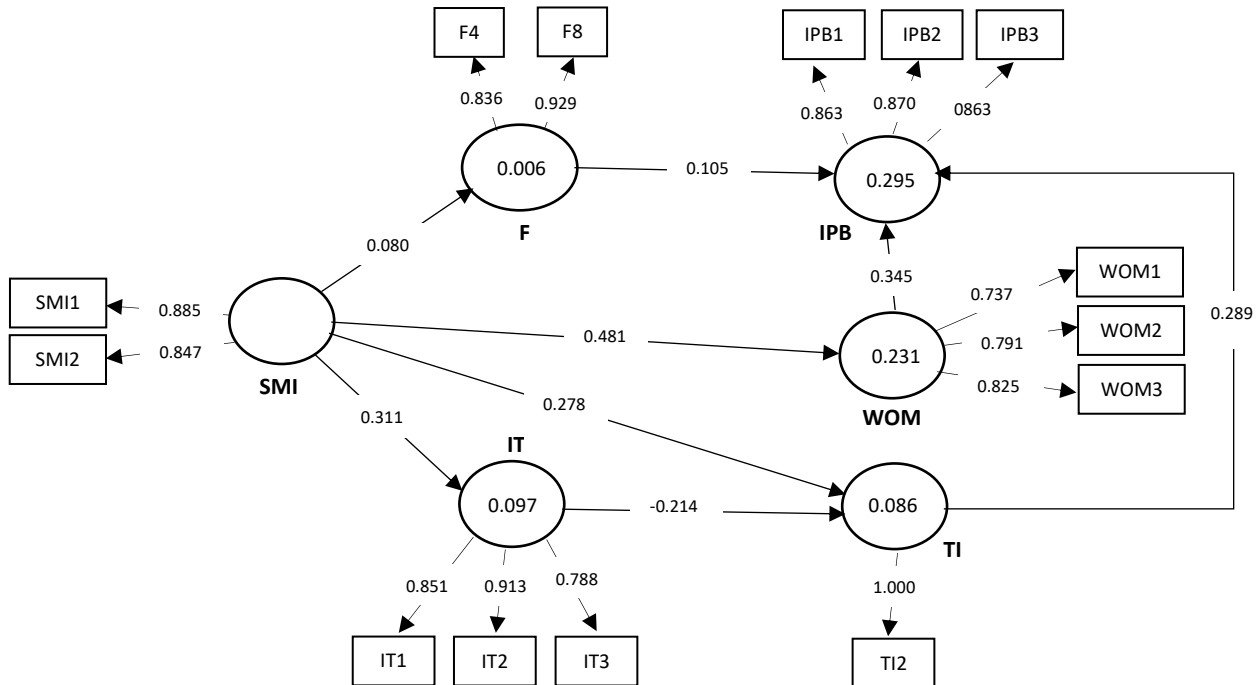


Figure 2 – Structural Model

Regarding the path coefficients (Table 9), H3 shows a negative coefficient (-0.214), suggesting an inverse relationship. The remaining coefficients, ranging from 0.080 to 0.481, indicate positive relationships of varying strength across the other hypotheses.

Table 9 - Path Coefficients – All generations

	Path coefficients	t-statistics	P value
H1: SMI -> WOM	0.481	13.002	0.000
H2: WOM -> IPB	0.345	8.797	0.000
H3: IT -> TI	-0.214	3.573	0.000
H4: SMI -> IT	0.311	7.017	0.000
H5: SMI -> FOMO	0.080	1.702	0.089
H6: FOMO -> IPB	0.105	2.328	0.020
H7: SMI -> TI	0.278	7.550	0.000
H8: TI -> IPB	0.289	7.534	0.000

The adjusted R-squared values (Table 10) show low explanatory power for FOMO (0.005), Travel Intentions (0.083), and Influencer Transparency (0.095), while Impulsive Purchasing Behavior (2.91) and Reliance on WOM from Influencers (0.230)



have moderate explanatory power. Path coefficients' significance was assessed separately via bootstrapping in the structural model.

Table 10 - Adjusted R-squared – All generations

	Adjusted R-square
FOMO	0.005
IPB	0.291
IT	0.095
TI	0.083
WOM	0.230

The f-square values (Table 11) show that Exposure to SMI strongly affects Reliance on WOM from Influencers (0.307) and moderately affects Influencer Transparency (0.107). Reliance on WOM moderately affects Impulsive Purchasing Behavior (0.158), while Travel Intentions has a small effect (0.097). Other effects, including Exposure to SMI on FOMO (0.006), FOMO on Impulsive Purchasing Behavior (0.013), and Influencer Transparency on Travel Intentions (0.045), are negligible, indicating minimal contribution to the variance of their dependent constructs.

Table 11 - f-square – All generations

	f-square
H1: SMI -> WOM	0.301
H2: WOM -> IPB	0.158
H3: IT -> TI	0.045
H4: SMI -> IT	0.107
H5: SMI -> FOMO	0.006
H6: FOMO -> IPB	0.013
H7: SMI -> TI	0.077
H8: TI -> IPB	0.097

Multicollinearity was assessed using the variance inflation factor (VIF), with all values above 2 indicating no potential multicollinearity issues (Kim, 2019). (Table 12).

Table 12 - VIF Collinearity Test – All generations

	FOMO	IPB	IT	TI	WOM
FOMO		1.156			
IT				1.107	
SMI	1.000		1.000	1.107	1.000
TI		1.216			
WOM		1.070			



4.3 MEDIATION ANALYSIS

Four mediation paths were tested using the bootstrapping technique (5,000 samples) in SmartPLS to determine whether specific variables mediate the relationship between the independent and dependent constructs.

The first mediation test showed that FOMO does not significantly mediate the relationship between Exposure to Social Media Influencers and Impulsive Purchasing Behavior ($\beta = 0.008$, $t = 1.219$, $p = 0.223$) (Table 13). The second mediation examined whether Reliance on WOM from Influencers mediates the relationship between Exposure to SMI and Impulsive Purchasing Behavior. The indirect effect was significant ($\beta = 0.166$, $t = 7.645$, $p < 0.001$), indicating that exposure to social media influencers affects impulsive purchases by increasing reliance on WOM from these influencers. The third mediation model assessed whether Travel Intentions mediate the relationship between Exposure to Social Media Influencers and Impulsive Purchasing Behavior. The indirect effect was significant ($\beta = 0.080$, $t = 4.715$, $p < 0.001$), indicating that Travel Intentions partially mediate the effect of influencer exposure on impulsive purchases. Lastly, the fourth mediation examined whether Influencer Transparency mediates the relationship between Exposure to Social Media Influencers and Travel Intentions (Table 13). The indirect effect was significant ($\beta = -0.067$, $t = 3.529$, $p < 0.001$), suggesting that higher perceived transparency is linked to lower travel intentions in this context.

Table 13 - Mediation Analysis

	Indirect effect	T statistics	P values
SMI -> FOMO -> IPB	0.008	1.219	0.223
SMI -> WOM -> IPB	0.166	7.645	0.000
SMI -> TI -> IPB	0.080	4.715	0.000
SMI -> IT -> TI	-0.067	3.529	0.000

4.4 MEASUREMENT INVARIANCE TEST - MICOM

To compare the structural model across different generational cohorts, it is essential to establish measurement invariance. The MICOM approach consists of three steps: (1) Configural invariance; (2) Compositional invariance; (3) Equality of composite mean values and variances (Henseler et al., 2016).

Establishing at least partial measurement invariance (steps 1 and 2) is a prerequisite for conducting multigroup analysis (MGA) and comparing path coefficients between generational groups.



4.4.1 MICOM PROCEDURE - CONFIGURAL INVARIANCE

4.4.1.1 CONFIGURAL INVARIANCE – GENERATION X, MILLENNIALS, AND GENERATION Z

Configural invariance was tested across Generation X, Millennials, and Generation Z. As shown in Table 14, all endogenous constructs yielded R-squared values within each group, indicating consistent model estimation. However, Generation Z had lower values for Travel Intentions (0.010) and FOMO (0.042).

Table 14 - Configural Invariance R-squared – All generations

	R-squared Gen X	R-squared Millennials	R-squared Gen Z
FOMO	0.078	0.200	0.042
IPB	0.291	0.695	0.171
IT	0.245	0.128	0.085
TI	0.050	0.410	0.010
WOM	0.199	0.264	0.141

The results show that most relationships follow the same direction, but the path varies by generation. For instance, Exposure to SMI significantly affects Reliance on WOM from Influencers across all generations, with the strongest among Millennials ($\beta = 0.514$). FOMO influences the Impulsive Purchasing Behavior relationship only for Millennials and Gen Z, highlighting younger consumers' greater impulsivity under social pressure. Influencer Transparency affects Travel Intentions only for Gen X ($p = 0.015$). Exposure to SMI impacts FOMO across all generations, highlighting apparent generational differences in behavioral paths.

Table 15 - Configural Invariance Path Coefficients – All generations

	Path coefficients Gen X	Path coefficients Millennials	Path coefficients Gen Z
H1: SMI -> WOM	0.446 ($p=0.000$)*	0.514 ($p=0.000$)*	0.376 ($p=0.000$)*
H2: WOM -> IPB	0.503 ($p=0.000$)*	0.072 ($p=0.272$)	0.102 ($p=0.212$)
H3: IT -> TI	-0.168 ($p=0.015$)*	-0.477 ($p=0.281$)	0.076 ($p=0.497$)
H4: SMI -> IT	0.495 ($p=0.000$)*	-0.358 ($p=0.327$)	0.291 ($p=0.000$)*
H5: SMI -> FOMO	-0.279 ($p=0.000$)*	0.448 ($p=0.000$)*	0.204 ($p=0.010$)*
H6: FOMO -> IPB	-0.090 ($p=0.325$)	0.302 ($p=0.000$)*	0.369 ($p=0.000$)*



H7: SMI -> TI	-0.086 (p=0.346)	0.290 (p=0.000)*	0.050 (p=0.520)
H8: TI -> IPB	-0.038 (p=0.626)	0.617 (p=0.000)*	0.048 (p=0.450)

* Note: indicates paths significant at $p < 0.05$

4.4.2 MICOM PROCEDURE - COMPOSITIONAL INVARIANCE

The second MICOM step tested compositional invariance by comparing composite correlations across generations. Invariance is supported when the original correlation is equal to or greater than the 5% quantile of the permutation distribution (Henseler et al., 2016). Most constructs exceed this threshold (e.g., Impulsive Purchasing Behavior and Travel Intentions). Influencer Transparency and FOMO showed lower correlations in some comparisons (e.g., Gen X vs Gen Z: FOMO = 0.960 vs 5% = 0.311), indicating partial compositional invariance and allowing further group analysis (Table 16).

Table 16 - Compositional Invariance

		Original correlation	5%
Generation X vs Millennials	FOMO	0.990	0.925
	IPB	1.000	0.998
	IT	0.184	0.932
	SMI	0.999	0.985
	TI	1.000	1.000
	WOM	0.997	0.966
Millennials vs Generation Z	FOMO	0.990	0.993
	IPB	0.998	0.999
	IT	0.159	0.180
	SMI	0.983	0.992
	TI	1.000	1.000
	WOM	0.933	0.979
Generation X vs Generation Z	FOMO	0.960	0.311
	IPB	0.994	0.984
	IT	1.000	0.994
	SMI	0.973	0.990
	TI	1.000	1.000
	WOM	0.952	0.981

4.4.3 MICOM PROCEDURE – MEANS AND VARIANCE DIFFERENCES

The third MICOM step tested equality of means and variances across generations using permutation p-values (<0.05). Constructs such as FOMO, Impulsive Purchasing Behavior, Travel Intentions, and Exposure to SMI showed significant differences, especially between Gen X and Gen Z, and Millennials and Gen Z (Table 17). While full



measurement invariance was not achieved, partial invariance allows meaningful multi-group analysis of structural path differences.

Table 17 - Means and Variance Differences

		Permutation p-value (mean)	Permutation p-value (variance)
Generation X vs Millennials	FOMO	0.000	0.000
	IPB	0.062	0.012
	IT	0.000	0.965
	SMI	0.163	0.368
	TI	0.000	0.000
	WOM	0.483	0.369
Millennials vs Generation Z	FOMO	0.001	0.377
	IPB	0.000	0.000
	IT	0.012	0.550
	SMI	0.000	0.023
	TI	0.000	0.000
	WOM	0.000	0.167
Generation X vs Generation Z	FOMO	0.000	0.004
	IPB	0.000	0.098
	IT	0.000	0.522
	SMI	0.000	0.000
	TI	0.003	0.399
	WOM	0.000	0.649

The analysis reveals distinct generational behaviors. Generation X relies on WOM from influencers, preferring trust-based decision-making over emotional triggers. Millennials are more responsive to emotional drivers, such as FOMO and travel intentions, affecting their impulsive purchases. Generation Z is affected by both emotional (FOMO) and trust-based (WOM) factors and perceives influencer transparency slightly more positively.

4.5 MULTI-GROUP ANALYSIS

Multi-Group Analysis examined structural differences across Generation X, Millennials, and Generation Z (Table 18). Several paths showed significant differences (< 0.05). For instance, Reliance on WOM from Influencers had a stronger effect on Impulsive Purchasing Behavior among Generation X than among Millennials and Generation Z ($p = 0.000$). Significant differences were also observed for paths involving Influencer Transparency and Exposure to SMI (e.g., effects on FOMO and Travel Intentions). Other paths, such as Exposure to SMI and Reliance on WOM from Influencers, were not significant ($p > 0.05$). Overall, while some influencer mechanisms are consistent across generations, key psychological drivers of impulsive purchasing vary, underscoring the need for generation-specific marketing strategies.

Table 18 - Multi-Group Analysis



		P values
Generation X vs Millennials	H1: SMI -> WOM	0.454
	H2: WOM -> IPB	0.000
	H3: IT -> TI	0.024
	H4: SMI -> IT	0.000
	H5: SMI -> FOMO	0.000
	H6: FOMO -> IPB	0.000
	H7: SMI -> TI	0.000
	H8: TI -> IPB	0.000
Millennials vs Generation Z	H1: SMI -> WOM	0.143
	H2: WOM -> IPB	0.751
	H3: IT -> TI	0.000
	H4: SMI -> IT	0.001
	H5: SMI -> FOMO	0.016
	H6: FOMO -> IPB	0.467
	H7: SMI -> TI	0.006
	H8: TI -> IPB	0.000
Generation X vs Generation Z	H1: SMI -> WOM	0.527
	H2: WOM -> IPB	0.000
	H3: IT -> TI	0.048
	H4: SMI -> IT	0.013
	H5: SMI -> FOMO	0.006
	H6: FOMO -> IPB	0.000
	H7: SMI -> TI	0.244
	H8: TI -> IPB	0.372



5. DISCUSSION

This section presents the study's conclusions and explores the potential reasons for the acceptance or rejection of each hypothesis, drawing on existing literature. The goal of this study is to examine the impact of exposure to social media influencers, influencer transparency, and FOMO on tourist behavior across distinct generations. To properly contextualize the MGA results, it is first necessary to determine whether each hypothesis was supported within each generation (Table 19).

Table 19 - Summary of hypothesis

Relationship	Generation X	Millennials	Generation Z
H1: SMI -> WOM	Supported	Supported	Supported
H2: WOM -> IPB	Supported	Not Supported	Not Supported
H3: IT -> TI	Supported	Not Supported	Not Supported
H4: SMI -> IT	Supported	Not Supported	Supported
H5: SMI -> FOMO	Supported	Supported	Supported
H6: FOMO -> IPB	Not Supported	Supported	Supported
H7: SMI -> TI	Not Supported	Supported	Not Supported
H8: TI -> IPB	Not Supported	Supported	Not Supported

After analyzing the results, it is possible to verify the hypotheses tested in this research across the different generations (Table 20):

Table 20 - Summary of MGA results

	Relationship	Result (MGA)
Generation X vs Millennials	H1: SMI -> WOM	No significant difference
	H2: WOM -> IPB	Significant difference
	H3: IT -> TI	Significant difference
	H4: SMI -> IT	Significant difference
	H5: SMI -> FOMO	Significant difference
	H6: FOMO -> IPB	Significant difference
	H7: SMI -> TI	Significant difference
	H8: TI -> IPB	Significant difference
Millennials vs Generation Z	H1: SMI -> WOM	No significant difference
	H2: WOM -> IPB	No significant difference
	H3: IT -> TI	Significant difference
	H4: SMI -> IT	Significant difference
	H5: SMI -> FOMO	Significant difference
	H6: FOMO -> IPB	No significant difference
	H7: SMI -> TI	Significant difference
	H8: TI -> IPB	Significant difference
Generation X vs Generation Z	H1: SMI -> WOM	No significant difference
	H2: WOM -> IPB	Significant difference
	H3: IT -> TI	Significant difference
	H4: SMI -> IT	Significant difference



H5: SMI -> FOMO	Significant difference
H6: FOMO -> IPB	Significant difference
H7: SMI -> TI	No significant difference
H8: TI -> IPB	No significant difference

Hypothesis 1 proposed that exposure to social media influencers would positively influence tourists' reliance on influencer WOM. The results showed that H1 was supported within all three generations, indicating that exposure to influencers consistently increases reliance on WOM from influencers. The MGA results showed no significant differences, meaning the strength of this relationship is similar across generations. Both Millennials and Generation X may still prioritize personal WOM from friends and family when planning trips (Jorgensen, 2003; Peterson & Merino, 2003), even though influencers are widely used, and sometimes perceived as opportunistic, deceitful, or manipulative (Borau-Boira et al., 2023).

Hypothesis 2 proposed that reliance on influencer WOM would increase impulsive purchasing behavior. The results showed that H2 was supported only for Generation X. In contrast, it was not supported for Millennials or Generation Z. This indicates that influencer WOM drives impulsive travel purchases among Gen X, consistent with prior findings showing that older travelers are more influenced by influencer recommendations, particularly when exposed to older influencers (Leung et al., 2025). Interestingly, this finding contrasts with research suggesting that Millennials tend to make faster and less deliberative decisions than other generations (Parment, 2009), resulting in more frequent impulsive purchases than Generation X (Lissitsa & Kol, 2016).

Hypothesis 3 proposed that influencer transparency would positively influence travel intentions. The results showed that H3 was supported only for Generation X, and not supported for Millennials or Generation Z. The MGA results further confirmed significant generational differences, highlighting that Gen X places greater trust in credible and professional influencer content, consistent with research emphasizing transparency and authenticity as key factors in travel-decision making (Borau-Boira et al., 2023). Prior studies also suggest that disclosures do not automatically reduce brand outcomes, such as purchase intention (De Jans et al., 2020; Mayrhofer et al., 2020). On the contrary, paid partnership disclosures can have a positive effect, with some studies showing that such transparency increases brand memory more than no disclosure or hashtag disclosure (Balaban et al., 2022), which can be particularly relevant in travel marketing.

Hypothesis 4 proposed that exposure to social media influencers would positively affect perceptions of influencer transparency. The results showed that H4 was supported for Generation X and Generation Z, but not for Millennials, indicating apparent generation differences. For Gen X and Gen Z, repeated exposure to influencer content, particularly when posts include clear disclosures, enhances followers' sense of transparency, which, in turn, positively affects their evaluation of



the promoted products and purchase intentions (Reynolds & Yuthas, 2008). In contrast, Millennials may be more critical or skeptical of influencer content. The MGA results confirmed significant generational differences. Additionally, prior research suggests that when audiences perceive the use of a persuasive tactic, the SMI is perceived as less transparent, and the brand's products are viewed as less effective (Woodroof et al., 2020).

Hypothesis 5 proposed that exposure to social media influencers increases tourists' FOMO. The results showed that H5 was supported for all three generations, indicating that influencer content consistently triggers feelings of missing out and encourages travel-related behaviors. Although the relationship is significant across all cohorts, the MGA results revealed generational differences in its strength, suggesting that some generations are more sensitive to FOMO-laden content than others. This aligns with prior research showing that FOMO-laden posts make audiences more likely to recommend destinations, underscoring the persuasive power of user-generated content in social media contexts. Interestingly, recommendation intentions tend to decline when friends or family share such content, as the urgency and novelty associated with FOMO are less effective when the endorsers are familiar figures (Lee et al., 2025). These findings highlight that social media influencers play a distinctive role in amplifying FOMO compared to personal connections.

Hypothesis 6 proposed that FOMO increases impulsive purchasing behavior in the tourism context. The results showed that H6 was not supported for Generation X, but supported for Millennials and Generation Z, indicating that FOMO may act as a more potent trigger for impulsive purchases of rewarding travel experiences or something valuable (Lee et al., 2025) among younger travelers. The MGA results confirmed significant differences between Gen X and both Millennials and Gen Z. These findings are consistent with previous research, which highlights that FOMO has reached peak relevance in today's society, particularly among younger consumers (Tippmann, 2023).

Hypothesis 7 proposed that exposure to social media influencers increases travel intentions. The results showed that H7 was supported only for Millennials. The MGA results revealed significant differences between Gen X and Millennials, and between Millennials and Gen Z. This finding aligns with previous studies showing that Millennials' attitudes toward social media influencer marketing positively influence their intention to visit endorsed destinations (Chatzigeorgiou, 2017) and that such attitudes are strongly linked to purchase intentions in both tourism and broader consumer contexts (Amaro & Duarte, 2015; Faculty of Economics and Management, Universiti Putra Malaysia Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia et al., 2017).

Finally, hypothesis 8 proposed that travel intentions positively impact impulsive purchasing behavior. The results showed that H8 was supported only for Millennials, following the same pattern observed in H7. The MGA results showed significant differences for comparisons involving Millennials, but not between Gen X and Gen Z.



These findings suggest that Millennials are particularly likely to translate travel intentions into impulsive purchases, consistent with their greater responsiveness to social media influence and faster decision-making tendencies compared to both older and younger cohorts (Lissitsa & Kol, 2016).



6. CONCLUSIONS

6.1 THEORETICAL CONTRIBUTIONS

This study contributes to tourism and social media literature by examining the exposure to social media influencers, impulsive purchasing behavior, FOMO, and travel intentions, while offering new insights that strengthen the growing body of work on influencer impact across generations, specifically Generation X, Millennials, and Generation Z. The findings also provide value for both academic research and practical applications, particularly for organizations seeking to optimize their influencer marketing strategies.

First, the study reveals important generational differences in responses to social media influencers. While prior research has explored influencer effects in tourism broadly (Pop et al., 2022), this study reveals that Generation X is particularly responsive to influencer-driven WOM and the FOMO phenomenon, leading to higher impulsive purchasing behavior. This enhances our theoretical understanding of the emotional and social drivers of travel decisions among older travelers.

Second, the study provides new evidence regarding Millennials' more deliberate and cautious approach to impulsive travel purchases. For this cohort, WOM and FOMO have weaker effects, suggesting that influencer marketing must focus on transparency, credibility, and informative content to engage Millennials effectively.

Third, the research sheds light on Generation Z's cost-conscious and deliberate travel behaviors. Although influencer transparency and emotional engagement remain important to this cohort, travel intentions shaped by influencers' exposure do not strongly translate into impulsive purchases. Consistent with recent research (Liu et al., 2023), this suggests that trust-building, value-oriented campaigns, and interactive content are more effective than purely aspirational or FOMO-based appeals.

Overall, this study provides a theoretical understanding of generational differences in consumer behavior and offers a foundation for future studies examining the evolving role of social media influencers in tourism.

6.2 MANAGERIAL IMPLICATIONS

The findings offer managerial insights for tourism marketers seeking to use influencer marketing effectively across generations.

Generation X travelers rely on influencer WOM and are sensitive to FOMO, which significantly drives impulsive purchasing behavior. For this cohort, campaigns should focus on platforms such as Facebook and Instagram and collaborate with credible influencers within the same age cohort (Leung et al., 2025) who deliver authentic recommendations and highlight limited-time travel opportunities. Tourism brands, hotels, travel agencies, or airlines can host Q&A sessions or live events on Instagram



and Facebook, presenting multiple offers and interacting directly with influencers from their age group to increase drive impulsive bookings.

For Millennials, exposure to influencers increases travel intentions, yet reliance on WOM or FOMO exerts weaker effects on impulsive purchases. Tourism brands should use Instagram and TikTok, featuring honest reviews, testimonials, and behind-the-scenes stories. Short travel guides or “top tips” videos can provide practical information, such as local restaurants, hidden gems, with links for bookings to facilitate seamless planning

Generation Z is deliberate and cost-conscious in travel decisions (Liu et al., 2023). Influencer campaigns should prioritize affordability, exclusive discounts, and authentic experiences, while FOMO strategies are less persuasive. Incorporating user-generated content, interactive formats, and themes of social responsibility can strengthen engagement with this generation, which values genuine, meaningful connections. After booking, Gen Z travelers could join a dedicated Instagram or TikTok channel where they can ask questions, share tips, and connect with fellow travelers. Each channel could feature a local influencer or “ambassador” per country, who hosts interactive polls and videos, providing guidance and fostering meaningful social connections.

Overall, this study highlights the importance of tailored influencer marketing strategies. By understanding generational motivations, tourism marketers can select appropriate influencers, allocate budgets more efficiently, and design targeted messages that enhance engagement and conversion.

6.3 LIMITATIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS FOR FUTURE RESEARCH

This study has limitations that should be considered when interpreting the results. First, while the MICOM procedure ensured measurement invariance, some relationships, particularly between Millennials and Generation Z, could not be thoroughly tested. Future research should refine measurement instruments to improve invariance and allow comprehensive cross-group testing.

Second, some hypotheses were unsupported, possibly due to the oversimplification of complex consumer processes. For example, the link between Exposure to SMI and Travel Intentions may be indirect and mediated by other psychological constructs. Qualitative studies, such as interviews or focus groups, could help uncover underlying explanations for these generational differences, including differences in platform usage or understanding of disclosure. Future models could also incorporate platform type or disclosure type as moderators to better capture these effects.

Third, the sample size has age-related limitations and national bias. Minors were not included, and respondents were primarily from a single country, potentially limiting generalizability. Generational distribution remained uneven (203 responses:



Generation Z, 180: Millennials, 169: Generation X), and convenience sampling may have introduced bias. Future research should adopt quota sampling or weighting to ensure a more balanced representation.

Fourth, the cross-sectional design collects data at a single point in time, providing a “snapshot” of consumer behavior. This approach limits the ability to assess causality or changes in generational responses over time. Longitudinal studies are recommended to investigate how exposure to influencer marketing evolves across different age cohorts.

Fifth, the reliance on self-reported questionnaires may be influenced by social desirability or recall bias. Future studies should combine surveys with objective behavioral data such as booking records, social media analytics, or digital footprint tracking, to validate responses.

Lastly, cultural or regional differences were not explored. Future cross-cultural research is recommended to explore how generational responses to influencer marketing vary across diverse sociocultural contexts.



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APPENDIX A



My name is Constança Oliveira, and I am conducting this study as part of my Master's thesis at NOVA IMS. This study explores the impact of social media influencers, transparency, and FOMO on tourist behavior across different generations. The target population includes people from Generation X, Millennials, and Generation Z who use social media and travel for leisure.

The estimated time to respond is approximately 5 minutes.



I declare that I am 18 or over 18 and agree to participate in this research. I declare that I was informed that my participation in this study is voluntary and that I can leave this survey at any time without penalty, and all data is confidential. I understand that I will evaluate responses and that this study does not offer serious risks.

☐ I agree to participate in this survey.

☐ I do not agree to participate in this survey.



Social media influencers leverage their online presence to promote brands, messages, products, or services while engaging with the targeted audiences on social media platforms. Travel social media influencers, in particular, focus on sharing their travel experiences, tips, and recommendations, often showcasing destinations, accommodations, and activities to inspire and inform followers.

Answer the following questions according to your personal experience:

Do you follow travel social media influencers?

☐ Yes

☐ No



Do you usually travel?

- ☐ Yes, several times a year
- ☐ Yes, once a year
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

How often do you access social media platforms?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ A few times per month
- ☐ A few times per week
- ☐ Daily

How much time do you usually spend on social media per day?

- ☐ Less than 30 minutes
- ☐ 30 minutes - 1 hour
- ☐ 1 - 2 hours
- ☐ 2 - 4 hours
- ☐ More than 4 hours



Which social media platform do you use the most?

☐ Instagram

☐ Facebook

☐ TikTok

☐ X (Twitter)

☐ YouTube

☐ Other. Which?

How often do you feel social media influencers influence your decision to buy something?

☐ Never

☐ Rarely

☐ Occasionally

☐ Frequently

☐ Very often



How frequently do you watch post/video content generated by social media influencers on social media?

☐ Rarely

☐ Occasionally

☐ Frequently

☐ Very often

How frequently do you watch selfies posted by social media influencers on social media?

☐ Never

☐ Rarely

☐ Occasionally

☐ Frequently

☐ Very often

How frequently do you watch live streaming of social media influencers on social media?

☐ Never

☐ Rarely

☐ Occasionally

☐ Frequently

☐ Very often



Answer the following questions according to your opinion about influencer transparency on a scale of 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 7 (Strongly Agree).

	Strongly disagree	Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Agree	Strongly agree
The influencers I follow are honest about the posts they are paid to make.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I can rely on the influencers I follow to post only products they believe in.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I can rely on the influencers I follow to post only products they personally use.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



Answer the following questions according to your opinion about social media influencers you follow on a scale of 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 7 (Strongly Agree).

	Strongly disagree	Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Agree	Strongly agree
I would like to continue following travel recommendations shared by social media influencers.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I would like to continue implementing travel suggestions I hear from social media influencers.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I intend to keep following travel recommendations from social media influencers rather than seeking advice from other sources.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
It is likely that I will continue to rely on travel recommendations from social media influencers in the future.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



Answer the following questions according to your opinion about your personal feelings or fears on a scale of 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 7 (Strongly Agree).

	Strongly disagree	Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree or disagree	Somewhat agree	Agree	Strongly agree
I fear others have more rewarding experiences than I.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I fear that my friends have more rewarding experiences than I do.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel worried when I find out my friends are having fun without me.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel anxious when I don't know what my friends are up to.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel it's important to understand my friends' inside jokes.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



I sometimes wonder if I spend too much time trying to keep up with what others are doing.

☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

I feel bothered when I miss an opportunity to meet up with friends.

☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

When I have a good time, I feel it's important to share details online (e.g., updating status).

☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

I feel bothered when I miss out on a planned get-together with friends.

☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

When I go on vacation, I continue to keep tabs on what my friends are doing.

☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

Answer the following questions according to your opinion about future trips on a scale of 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 7 (Strongly Agree).

	Strongly disagree	Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Agree	Strongly agree
I intend to take another leisure trip soon.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Before long, I really want to travel to a new destination.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I will try to go on a trip in the near future.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



Answer the following questions according to your opinion about purchase behavior on a scale of 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 7 (Strongly Agree).

	Strongly disagree	Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Agree	Strongly agree
I ended up spending more money on travel than I originally planned.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I booked more trips and travel experiences than I had planned.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I indulged in impulsive travel decisions.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



With which gender do you identify?

☐ Male

☐ Female

☐ Non-binary / third gender

☐ Other

☐ Prefer not to say

How old are you? (numbers only)

What is your nationality?



What is your highest level of education?

- ☐ Primary school
- ☐ High school
- ☐ Bachelor's degree
- ☐ Master's degree
- ☐ PhD degree

What is your current professional situation?

- ☐ Student
- ☐ Part-time employed
- ☐ Full-time employed
- ☐ Self-employed
- ☐ Unemployed
- ☐ Retired
- ☐ Other



What is your monthly net income?

☐ Less than €1.000

☐ €1.000 - €1.999

☐ €2.000 - €2.999

☐ €3.000 - €3.999

☐ €4.000 - €4.999

☐ More than €5.000

☐ Prefer not to answer



ANNEX A

This is to certify that

Project No.: **DDMKT2025-4-306565**

Project Title: **The impact of Social Media Influencers, Influencer Transparency and FOMO on tourist behavior: Generational Differences – Gen X, Millennials and Gen Z**

Principal Researcher: **Constança Oliveira**

according to the regulations of the Ethics Committee of NOVA IMS and MagIC Research Center this project was considered to meet the requirements of the NOVA IMS Internal Review Board, being considered **APPROVED** on 5/7/2025.

It is the Principal Researcher's responsibility to ensure that all researchers and stakeholders associated with this project are aware of the conditions of approval and which documents have been approved.

The Principal Researcher is required to notify the Ethics Committee, via amendment or progress report, of

- Any significant change to the project and the reason for that change;
- Any unforeseen events or unexpected developments that merit notification;
- The inability of the Principal Researcher to continue in that role or any other change in research personnel involved in the project.

Lisbon, 5/7/2025

Data with Purpose.

